

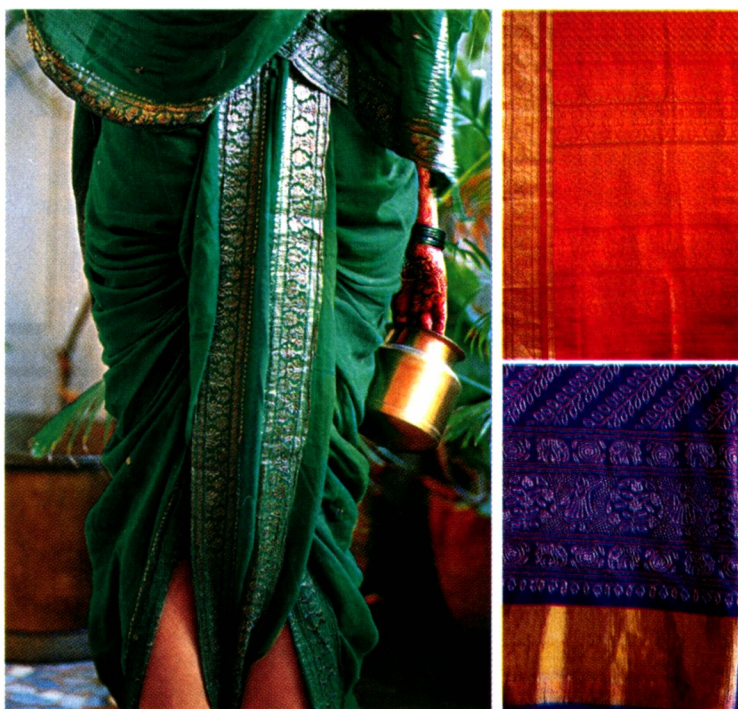
THERE ARE
108 WAYS TO
TIE A SARI

caricature of themselves. Off-shoulder, tight-fitting evening gowns that have become the rage today amongst young women who are trying to be something they are not, look equally odd and ungainly. Very few foreign clothes and styles work for Indians. Most manage to look rather absurd, like in a fancy dress, or in a costume for a vaudeville show. The sari scores high marks for appropriate elegance. The colours of India, with their nuanced and subtle shades that traverse an elaborate spectrum from light to dark, suit the varied tones and complexions of women from different parts of this sprawling and diverse subcontinent. Fabrics indigenous to

exceptional weaving centres of Benaras and Kanchipuram, is a must for every individual home library. It is a meticulously researched, comprehensive visual compendium of the weaves of India—a bible of sorts. The diversity it establishes is phenomenal. Chishti takes a long journey, a Bharat Darshan, to identify, then collate to conserve, document and restore not only the details of different sari weaves but also, 108 ways to tie and drape these lengths of cloth. There are some charming visuals scattered through the book, particularly one of a woman riding a cycle in her traditional style from Maharashtra where one end is swept up between the legs and tucked into the back of the waist thereby allowing the woman to sit cross saddle in comfort.

Fortunately, those who discarded the sari, lungi, munda vastra, ghagra, lehnga and salwar-kameez for Western gear were few and far between in numbers. A majority continue to wear traditional clothes and that is what kept the looms and skills going, the textile and weaving tradition alive in India. What we wove, we used. What will survive will be that which women in India will continue to use. Carpets, durries, shawls and blankets, cloth and sari lengths were all intrinsic to live and living and will live on if there is a demand. Sadly, the Indian male, in sharp contrast to the Indian woman, gave up his rather splendid dress styles and opted for the dull and uniform suit, trouser and shirt. The elegant dhoti has near disappeared in India. The kurta pyjama is not worn to work. The acchkan and bandgala is marketed today as “wedding wear” referred to as ethnic, a definition Indians have not understood because traditional dress in India is not “ethnic” for Indians.

Exquisite saris beckon those of us who wear them. For me they are my greatest treasures, bought from wherever I have been fortunate enough to travel, often directly off the looms, sometimes in local small town markets, every now and again from exhibitions. They have all been worn with much joy. My abiding love for the many weaves, textures and colours that make the warp and weft of India was instilled in me by my mother who bought me my first saris, one khadi and the other chanderi, when I was 10 years old. I still have them. Congratulations to Roli Books and Priya Kapoor, the publishers, for having participated in this wonderful, fruitful journey. The high quality and design of the book is a pleasure to the eye and the cover picture symbolises both the sari and the Indian woman on the move. ■



specific regions, woven in their cultural context, breathe happily in their contained environment. Motifs as well as colour tell stories, establish what has to be worn when and where, according to carefully constructed codes. This heritage is a precious legacy of an ancient civilisation. It deserves to be treasured as it unravels the social history, the complex warp and weft, of a culture, of many cultures. From these roots, generational change, additions and subtractions to and from the design directory and the frame, can evolve, change and ensure a sense of belonging.

Rta Kapur Chishti's directory of India's unrivalled skill of the hands that create unimaginable textiles, lengths of fabric that come off the looms of India from the small, anonymous hamlets and villages across the many regions and states, to the